

The effects of relationship bonds on bank employees' psychological responses and boundary-spanning behaviors

An empirical examination of the JD–R model

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Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this paper is to examine the effects of relationship bonds on the psychological response and behavior of bank employees based on the job demands-resources theory. Specifically, it examines the effects of relationship bonds in terms of person–job (P–J) fit, emotional exhaustion, job satisfaction and boundary-spanning behaviors, all of which comprise the behavioral dimensions of bank employees. In addition, the study examines how the resiliency of bank employees influences their emotional exhaustion and determines whether a moderating effect related to emotional exhaustion exists.

Design/methodology/approach – To achieve this aim, data were collected from 365 customer-facing banking employees in South Korea. Reliability, validity and the hypotheses were verified through structural equation modeling; any moderating effects were identified using the bootstrap method and the process model.

Findings – Study results showed that financial, structural, internal social and external social bonds – the bonds pertaining to relationship elements – have positive effects on P–J fit. P–J fit influenced emotional exhaustion negatively and job satisfaction positively. Furthermore, emotional exhaustion negatively influenced job satisfaction. Job satisfaction had positive effects on service delivery, external representation and internal influence, the elements comprising boundary-spanning behavior. Finally, resiliency was shown to lower emotional exhaustion but revealed no moderating effect.

Originality/value – First, this study examined relationship bonds, which reference relationship marketing when introducing organizational resources that influence the psychological and behavioral responses of bank employees. Second, this study introduced resiliency as a personal resource and clarified the way it applies to an individual's psychological response. Third, existing literature has been limited to conducting fragmented research of the psychological factors that intervene in predisposing factors and job outcomes. This study makes a unique contribution by establishing a psychological response process.

Keywords P–J fit, Job satisfaction, Emotional exhaustion, JD–R model, Boundary-spanning behaviour, Relationship bonds

Paper type Research paper

1. Introduction

Over the last decade, one major interest in the research field of the banking and financial industry has been an examination of employee perceptions and attitudes. Bank employees serve as boundary spanners, in that they connect the organization and its customers (Sengupta *et al.*, 2015), and their responses to customers determine the quality of the service that is perceived by customers (Yoo and Jung, 2019). Thus, all bank organizations should understand the perceptions and attitudes of employees from the level of accomplishing management goals and provide support to ensure that employees can play this role effectively (Kaur, 2015). For this reason, an investigation into employees' perceptions from the perspective of the general bank environment is necessary (Yoo and Jung, 2019).



Examinations conducted by previous studies on bank employees have important research gaps. First, until now, studies have presumed that individual and organizational resources were distal determinants that influence job behaviors and outcomes (Sengupta *et al.*, 2015) and have identified that the variables aligned with bank employees' psychological and emotional states intervene between resource factors and job outcomes (Karatepe and Aga, 2016; Yoo and Jung, 2019). However, previous studies on bank employees fragmentarily identified a psychological mechanism formed between the resource factors and the job outcomes; thus, they provide only limited understanding.

Second, previous studies have examined organizational resources relevant to bank employees with a focus on the single domain factors for performance improvement, such as training and service technology (Sengupta *et al.*, 2015), coaching (Pousa *et al.*, 2017) and organizational support (Karatepe and Aga, 2016). Studies on individual resources have focused on investigating the characteristics related to bank employees' tasks, such as service orientation (Yoo and Jung, 2019), customer orientation (Sengupta *et al.*, 2015; Yoo, 2016) and sales orientation (Pousa *et al.*, 2018). However, since the factors serving as resources for bank employees are vast and diverse (Bakker *et al.*, 2004), it is important to diagnose the mechanisms related to individual- and organization-level resources present in domains other than that of the work process; meanwhile, the corresponding related knowledge is scarce (Karatepe *et al.*, 2019).

This study was conducted to supplement the gap left by previous research in the bank industry. Specifically, it explored the role of "relationship bonds," a strategy through which relationships are formed by perceiving bank employees as internal customers in terms of organizational resources. Relationship bonds constitute a determinant that improves relationship performance and is revealed by an employees' job attitude and level of behavior (Lee *et al.*, 2019). In addition, resiliency was examined as a personal resource for bank employees. Resiliency is a universal personal psychological trait that can strengthen the ability of an employee to control him or herself in stressful situations (Luthans *et al.*, 2006; Krush *et al.*, 2013), but no study related to resiliency has been conducted on bank employees.

Next, the relationship between relationship bonds and boundary-spanning behaviors, which is a major role for bank employees (in particular, the psychological response process comprising person–job (P–J) fit, emotional exhaustion and job satisfaction), was examined and the effects of resiliency on the psychological response process were explored. To this end, the hypotheses and research model used in this study were developed and evaluated based on the job demands–resources (JD–R) model and previous studies. The JD–R model explains how diverse factors that apply to individuals emerge as organizational outcomes through job strain or psychological processes related to motivation. The model, which illustrates a theory that was developed through the integration of previous studies and theories to explain personal behaviors on the job, can be applied to an extensive array of jobs and working environments (Bakker and Demerouti, 2007) and a number of studies support the JD–R model's process (Lazauskaite-Zabielske *et al.*, 2018; Hu *et al.*, 2016; Schmitz and Ganesan, 2014).

This study's contributions to existing bank marketing are as follows: first, it examined relationship bonds reflecting the concept of relationship marketing when introducing organizational resources that influence the psychological and behavioral responses of bank employees. Previous studies on relationship marketing emphasize the importance of the relationship between an organization and its members but lack empirical evidence in an academic context. This study contributed to an expansion of literature by suggesting empirical evidence showing that relationship bonds elicit positive behavior through the psychological response of bank employees.

Second, this study introduced resiliency as a personal resource and identified the way it applies to the employee psychological response. Resiliency, the personal ability to recover from

stress (Masten and Reed, 2002), is an important characteristic for bank employees, who frequently experience stressful situations when interacting with customers. This study expanded the knowledge related to the personal resources of bank employees by examining resiliency.

Third, existing literature has only focused on conducting fragmented research focused on determining which psychological factors intervene in the predisposing factors and job outcomes; this study is unique, as it established the psychological response process. Thus, this study provided an expanded understanding of the psychological mechanism that is formed between resource factors and job outcomes.

2. Theoretical background

2.1 The JD–R model

The JD–R model has been designed to describe how burnout and engagement are generated in employees. The key to the JD–R model is the assumption that specific elements that can be classified into job demands and resources exist (Bakker and Demerouti, 2007; Demerouti *et al.*, 2001; Zablah, Chonko, Bettencourt, Allen and Haas, 2012).

Job demands are related to physical, social, mental and organizational aspects, and require continuous efforts for job performance. Furthermore, when satisfactory compensations are not provided, employees' emotional state is negatively influenced or stressful elements are created. Conversely, job resources reduce the efforts needed for job demands and lower the physical and psychological costs. In addition, the resources support employees' ability to achieve their job objectives and can enable them to grow in their role, learn and generate other positive developments (Demerouti *et al.*, 2001). In this study, which expanded the JD–R model, resources related to the job and the personal resources related to individual characteristics were shown to exist and effects of resources on emotions were demonstrated (Bakker and Demerouti, 2008).

Bakker and Demerouti (2007) stated that two types of psychological processes occur within the JD–R model. The first is related to strain. Job demands prompt strain in job situations and lead to negative organizational performance. The second is the motivational process. Job resources lead to motivation and help employees accomplish positive outcomes. In addition to these two psychological processes, job demands and resources generate a buffer effect toward the motivational and strain processes, respectively. Thus, the effects of job demands and resources are reduced in each process. Identifying the elements that constitute the resources in a work environment can be useful in managing the psychological and emotional states of bank employees. Therefore, it is important to examine the resources related to a job and the personal resources.

2.2 Relationship bonds

Relationship marketing is related to all marketing activities that successfully establish, develop and maintain relational exchange (Morgan and Hunt, 1994). The term "relationship marketing" was first mentioned by Berry (1983, p. 25) in the service literature and was defined as that which induces, maintains and improves customer relationships in multi-service organizations (Hunt *et al.*, 2006). The initial purpose of relationship marketing was to maintain the commitment relationship between customers and organizations (Hsieh *et al.*, 2005) and has been drawing attention in marketing theory and practice as an effective strategy for organizations to use in forming, maintaining and enhancing its customer relationships (Ward and Daggar, 2007; Huang, 2008). Although the early form of relationship marketing focused on the context of the relationship between organizations and customers (Hsieh *et al.*, 2005), relationship marketing has been expanded to strengthen the relationship between organizations and employees owing to their significant role in the relationship between organizations and their customers (Wang, 2014). A previous study

mentioned that economic, physical and psychological attachments develop due to the interactions through relational exchanges. Similarly, the relationship bonds resulting due to diverse relationships are mainly divided into financial, structural and social bonds (Liang and Chen, 2009; Wang, 2014).

Financial bond is the basis of the relationship bonds used by organizations to form relationships with customers, which strengthens relationships with customers by offering economic benefits. This refers to the formation of relationships resulting from the provision of economic benefits, such as discounts and incentives (Hsieh *et al.*, 2005; Lin *et al.*, 2003). The financial bond, which aims to guarantee customer loyalty based on economic benefits, is the most basic strategy for forming relationships compared to other types of relationship bonds (Berry, 1995; Berry and Parasuraman, 1991). Financial bonds are related to the economically dependent aspects of various relationships. From the perspective of a bank employee, financial bonds are related to the efforts of the bank organization to satisfy the financial aspect through economic incentives, such as wages (Wang, 2014). In other words, the financial bonds of employees are actualized based on their wage level. When other organizations provide higher wages and economic support, maintaining the financial bonds with their organization becomes difficult. Providing economic benefits leads employees to immerse themselves in the organization (Melancon *et al.*, 2011). Since the employees who are satisfied with their economic compensation feel guilty when they leave the organization, their intention to maintain the relationship becomes stronger (Wang, 2014).

Structural bonds create a customization value for customers (Chiu *et al.*, 2007). The customization value appears in two main cases. First, it appears when the relationship with customers has been strengthened by the company's valuable services, which are difficult to obtain from other sources, and in resolving the problems of customers. When customers receive valuable services, it allows them to become more productive and effective by offering a comprehensive set of services. It also references the provision of innovative products or services tailored to the demands of customers (Hsieh *et al.*, 2005). Second, structural bonds are formed when authority has been granted in the joint decision making that is performed by customers alongside partners. The authority to make decisions in the exchange relationships with a partner facilitates the opportunity to generate the customization value for customers, and they feel greater satisfaction in their relationships owing to the strengthening of structural bonds (Bolton *et al.*, 2003). When looking at structural bonds from the perspective of bank employees, the bank makes an effort to implement policy, procedures and programs to design work tailored to individuals and offer additional values customized to employee needs. That is, decision making related to establishing working hours and adjusting schedules can enhance the customization value felt by employees in their role (Wang, 2014).

Social bonds are connected to positive interpersonal relationships and play a significant role in relationship development (Kuenzel and Krolikowska, 2008). In general, social bonds refer to the degree of mutual sharing of personal closeness and information in interpersonal relationships (Liang and Wang, 2005; Wang, 2014). Bank employees – the boundary spanners between the bank organization and its customers – experience interpersonal interactions both inside and outside organizations. If organizations assist and allow employees to form suitable social relationships, they can make affective and normative commitments in their relationship with their organizations (Wang, 2014). In that sense, the organizations' efforts to establish social relationships of employees lead to social bond formation. Internal social bonds refer to the efforts of bank organizations to establish and maintain relationships between bank employees through communication. Smooth communication and the relational exchange process among employees form intimacy and result in reliability (Rodríguez and Wilson, 2002); this, in turn, benefits employees in terms of both their psychological and emotional states (Wang, 2014).

Similar to internal social bonds, external social bonds signify that an organization assists in sharing informational and relational value through the employees' customer interactions, through which they maintain their personal intimacy (Biong and Ulvnes, 2011). Personal contact should occur when employees physically approach a customer to skillfully deliver sale and other relevant services to him or her. In that sense, intimate interaction with customers is necessary. Employees and customers understand each other through the shared information (Nahapiet and Ghoshal, 1998). Through this process, employees can obtain a clearer and more practical confirmation of customer issues. Thus, employees can suggest solutions that meet the stated needs of customers and have a positive impact in terms of the psychological and emotional dimensions of their role by achieving the objectives of their role.

2.3 The relationship between relationship bonds and P-J fit

P-J fit pertains to whether the special requirements of individuals and a job coincide. In general, such a fit can be identified by determining whether the knowledge, skills and abilities of an employee coincide with the requirements of a given job (Kristof-Brown, 2000). P-J fit is mainly divided into two types. The first type is the abilities-demand fit, which pertains to whether the conditions required to perform a job coincide with the employees' abilities or skills. If they possess the ability to perform the job, employees can perform the duties entailed in the role and achieve a high level of performance. The second type is the needs-supplies fit. This type of fit is achieved when, for example, a job satisfies the wage needs of an individual (Yoo, 2013). In the initial research related to P-J fit, two studies – one focused on abilities-demand fit and the other on needs-supplies fit – were conducted. However, the two types of fit have since been combined into one general concept, which is now in use (Cable and Derue, 2002; Scroggins, 2007). The employee seeks to fulfill individual needs and then endeavors to perform jobs with a high level of compatibility with his or her individual characteristics. Meanwhile, the organization endeavors to seek employees who possess the skills and abilities necessary to perform a given job.

Financial bonds refer to the efforts of bank organizations to stimulate the economic satisfaction of employees through economic incentives, such as wages (Wang, 2014). One external motive that applies to employees is related to the financial dimension (Melancon *et al.*, 2011), which exerts influence on behavior by eliciting the employee's emotions (Read, 2005). Obtaining economic benefits from an organization constitutes a significant motivator for employees (Joseph and Dai, 2010) and is related to their economic reliance on bank organizations. Thus, bank employees react sensitively when they feel they are receiving unfair wages compared to the amount of work that is done (Newman and Sheikh, 2012). On the contrary, when the economic stability of employees has been satisfied due to ample financial compensation from an organization, the needs-supplies fit is satisfied because the need of the individual has also been met.

Structural bonds refer to efforts, such as adjusting working hours, to process the tasks of bank employees in the most convenient and efficient manner and adjust schedules to align with their needs. This concept encompasses the job policies, procedures and designs tailored to the respective employees (Wang, 2014). Such flexibility in the working system can assist employees in immersing themselves in their jobs (Martin and MacDonnell, 2012). Flexibly adjusting schedules guide employees to perceive the flexibility as effort on the part of their organizations to help them balance work and life. Since employees demand a balance between work and life from their organizations, they perceive flexible work schedules as the organization's effort to take care of its members (Giannikis and Mihail, 2008). Therefore, when structural bonds, such as a flexible work schedule, have been satisfied, the P-J fit of employees is enhanced since the needs-supplies fit has been satisfied.

Internal social bonds refer to the support of an organization, which enables streamlined personal intimacy and communication among employees through their interpersonal interactions (Liang and Wang, 2005; Wang, 2014). In interpersonal relationships, social bonds assist employees in forming an affective commitment (Wang, 2014). Individuals' wish to satisfy their social sense of belonging and relational needs is satisfied when they form social bonds within an organization. Moreover, the relational support in a bank organization promotes a flow of information and enhances the possibility of resolving any problems arising from work (Felicio *et al.*, 2014). As such, the abilities or skills of employees improve when they perform tasks. This satisfies both the abilities–demands and the needs–supplies fit.

Finally, external social bonds refer to the support of the bank organization, which enables the sharing of relational and informational values with customers based on employee–customer interaction (Biong and Ulvnes, 2011). The relationship formation between employees and customers plays an integral role in the development of business relationships and is closely related to positive interpersonal relationships. Bank employees must prioritize the formation of relationships to achieve positive job performance. The relationship that has been established through interactions between customers and employees is characterized by mutual trust and equality (Bolino *et al.*, 2002) and the two sides can achieve mutual understanding by sharing information (Nahapiet and Ghoshal, 1998). Employees can accomplish their job objectives by recommending financial products that can resolve customer issues. The relationships with customers are essential in performing employee tasks, which satisfies the abilities–demand fit. As such, the following hypotheses are established:

H1a. Financial bonds will increase the P–J fit of bank employees.

H1b. Structural bonds will increase the P–J fit of bank employees.

H1c. Internal social bonds will increase the P–J fit of bank employees.

H1d. External social bonds will increase the P–J fit of bank employees.

2.4 The relationships between P–J fit, emotional exhaustion and job satisfaction

Burnout refers to the emotional response to chronic stress; customer-facing employees who regularly deal with customers experience such burnout (Lewin and Sager, 2009). A previous study on burnout mentions three types: diminished personal accomplishment, depersonalization and emotional exhaustion (Maslach and Jackson, 1981). Diminished personal accomplishment signifies a simultaneous reduction in work accomplishment and work efficiency. Depersonalization occurs when employees perceive that an important factor in their job is uncontrollable and random, and is a dysfunctional response to job-related stress. Finally, emotional exhaustion is a response toward job-related stress that appears when employees feel emotionally burnt out (Brotheridge and Grandey, 2002; Lewin and Sager, 2009). Emotional exhaustion is the key element comprising burnout (Boles *et al.*, 1997) and can be applied to extensive and diverse job situations since it is an indicator used to evaluate accumulated stress (Gaines and Jermier, 1983).

P–J fit is related to improving job satisfaction, self-efficacy and an individual's positive attitude toward his or her job and organization (Lauver and Kristof-Brown, 2001; Saks and Ashforth, 2002), and it can have positive effects on the emotional state. When the abilities–demand fit dimensions needed by employees to perform tasks are satisfied, the difficulties and pressure involved in job performance are diminished. On the contrary, when they are not satisfied, the burden experienced by employees related to their job is increased. Meanwhile, when an employee's individual needs, which are met by his or her job, for the needs–supplies fit dimension are not satisfied, he or she will experience difficulties and stress. On the contrary, when his or her individual needs and those related to job

performance are both met, the burden of job performance is reduced (Yoo, 2013). Therefore, when individual needs are fulfilled in the job dimension, the emotional exhaustion employees experience related to their job will diminish and their job satisfaction will increase. Thus, the following hypotheses are established:

H2. P-J fit will reduce the emotional exhaustion of bank employees.

H3. P-J fit will increase the job satisfaction of bank employees.

Many studies have demonstrated that emotionally exhausted employees are dissatisfied with their tasks and have negative attitudes (Karatepe and Tekinkus, 2006; Karatepe *et al.*, 2009; Karatepe, 2013). Emotional exhaustion causes a significant physical and psychological burden for bank employees (Cordes and Dougherty, 1993) and they lose interest in their job. That is, the employees who experience emotional exhaustion are unable to maintain a positive and proactive attitude in their job (Judge and Bono, 2001). In addition, since a huge amount of energy is needed to resolve the psychological fatigue that stems from their emotional exhaustion, their attitude toward their job becomes negative (Halbesleben and Buckley, 2004; Perrewé *et al.*, 2004). Based on the aforementioned findings, the following hypothesis is proposed:

H4. Emotional exhaustion will reduce the job satisfaction of bank employees.

2.5 *The effects and the moderating effect of the resiliency regarding emotional exhaustion*

Resiliency refers to the psychological resource through which an individual can overcome and recover from diverse stressful situations (Luthar *et al.*, 2000; Tugade and Fredrickson, 2004). Previous studies explain resiliency as the psychological characteristic of actively adjusting and recovering from grave difficulties and hardships in life (Masten and Reed, 2002). Individuals with high resiliency have been found to derive positive outcomes despite the degradation of their health functions and a stressful situation or environment that discourages ordinary development (Baumgardner and Crothers, 2009).

In particular, resiliency is important for bank employees who experience conflict situations. High resiliency helps employees reduce job-related stress (Leach *et al.*, 2005) and maintains their personal motivation during job performance (Krush *et al.*, 2013). Such resiliency alleviates the negative effects from stress that employees have already experienced in job-related situations. Meanwhile, employees with high resiliency can not only focus on their work by forming and maintaining cognitive and sentimental resources but also control their stress (Krush *et al.*, 2013). In addition, resiliency – the personal resource for reducing the effects of stress – can control emotions (Fredrickson and Joiner, 2002). When considering the fact that the resource dimension reduces the psychological costs required in a given job according to the JD-R model, resiliency directly lowers emotional exhaustion by reducing employees' psychological costs (Demerouti *et al.*, 2001). In summary, resiliency itself is a personal resource, reduces emotional exhaustion and lowers the effects of stress by helping employee make a calm and swift recovery from stressful situations. Thus, the following hypotheses are established:

H5. The resiliency of bank employees will reduce emotional exhaustion.

H6. As the resiliency of bank employees increases, the effect of P-J fit reducing emotional exhaustion will be strengthened.

H7. As the resiliency of bank employees increases, the effect of emotional exhaustion reducing job satisfaction will be weakened.

2.6 *Job satisfaction and boundary-spanning behaviors*

Boundary spanners not only interact with those outside of the organization, such as customers, but also influence the employees (Adams, 1976). Boundary-spanning behavior

can be defined as the customer-facing employee behavior performed by employees in the role of boundary spanner (Bettencourt *et al.*, 2001; Chebat and Kollias, 2000). Previous studies have mentioned that customer-facing employees play three key boundary spanner roles (Bettencourt *et al.*, 2001; Van Dyne *et al.*, 1994).

The first role is to satisfy customers with a high quality of service; the perception and satisfaction of service quality are related to customer-facing employees' behaviors, such as courtesy, personal attentiveness, responsiveness and follow-through on promises (Parasuraman *et al.*, 1988). The second role relates to employees' representation of the company to outsiders, supporting corporate products and services, and improving the image and legitimacy of the company (Adams, 1976; Booms and Bitner, 1981; Bowen and Schneider, 1985). The third role is related to sharing information and distributing opportunities regarding improvements to meet the varied requests of customers, and ensure product and service delivery (Schneider and Bowen, 1985). Regarding such boundary-spanning behaviors, previous studies have identified that attitude factors related to one's job exerted an influence (Bettencourt *et al.*, 2005).

Job satisfaction refers to employees' attitude toward their job and organization (Rad and Yarmohammadian, 2006). Employees' job attitude improves their self-esteem and loyalty toward the organization and is directly related to corporate performance measures, such as an increase in productivity (Brashear *et al.*, 2004). Job satisfaction is the attitude that influences one's motives and serves as the stimulant that leads to performance. Employees who are satisfied with their job exhibit higher performance than those who are not. Thus, employees can perform better when they are satisfied with their jobs since they apply more effort to achieve their goals (Atmojo, 2012; Schmitz and Ganesan, 2014). Employees should offer high-quality services to customers to improve their performance and also express positive sentiments related to their organization. Bank employees with high job satisfaction provide quality services to customers and improve their performance by expressing positive sentiments about their bank organization. In addition, the employees with high job satisfaction prioritize their organization, which leads to altruistic behaviors (Netemeyer *et al.*, 1997; Organ and Lingl, 1995). As such, the following hypotheses can be established:

H8a. The job satisfaction of bank employees will increase service delivery.

H8b. The job satisfaction of bank employees will increase external representation.

H8c. The job satisfaction of bank employees will increase internal influence.

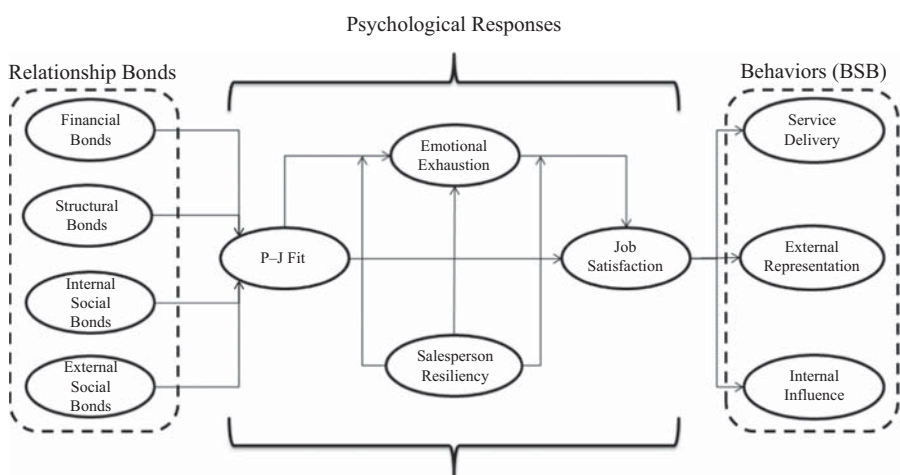
Based on the research hypotheses, we developed the hypothetical research model as shown in Figure 1.

3. Research methodology

3.1 Data collection and survey sample characteristics

This study conducted questionnaire surveys targeting retail bank employees in South Korea in the Summer 2018. To administer the surveys, a panel from a professional online survey institute with the largest platform in South Korea was used. The corresponding survey institute panel is not limited to a certain organization or area and only those who have volunteered can serve on a panel. In addition, the survey institute induces voluntary participation from those who joined the panel by providing points online that can be converted into cash after filling out the questionnaire survey. Prior to conducting the survey, survey targets were chosen using three steps. First, after several jobs were suggested, participants were asked to select the one that applied to them. In this stage, the participants who did not engage with customers were removed. Next, after suggesting diverse industries related to employees who interact with customers, they chose the industry to which they belonged; participants who chose an industry other than banking

Figure 1.
Research model



were removed. Finally, participants were asked to choose which bank they belonged to and were given the option to select either a wholesale or a retail bank. The removed participants no longer took part in the survey and there is no sample selection bias issue. The survey responses of 365 retail bank employees comprised the final sample size.

The following are the demographic characteristics of the samples used in this study. In terms of gender, 204 were men (55.9 percent) and 161 were women (44.1 percent). A total of 127 participants were in their 30s (34.8 percent); 111 participants were in their 40s (30.4 percent); 83 participants were in their 20s (22.7 percent); and 44 participants were in their 50s or older (12.1 percent). In terms of academic background, 249 participants graduated from university (68.2 percent); 90 graduated from high school (24.7 percent); 14 were either attending or had graduated from graduate school (3.8 percent); and 12 participants were attending university (3.3 percent). In addition, 104 participants had less than 3 years of experience (28.5 percent); 88 had between 3 and 6 years of experience (24.1 percent); 73 participants had more than 12 years of experience (20 percent); 52 participants had between 6 and 9 years of experience (14.2 percent); and 48 participants had between 9 and 12 years of experience (13.2 percent). In terms of rank in the workplace, 185 participants were employees (50.7 percent); 77 participants were section chiefs (21.1 percent); 74 participants were deputy section chiefs (20.3 percent); and 29 participants were the head of a department or of a higher rank (7.9 percent). Table I reports the demographic characteristics of the samples used in this study.

3.2 Measurement of variables

The scale used in this study was adapted from those used in previous studies to meet the research criteria and objectives. The items selected were measured using a five-point Likert scale and scale items are shown in the Appendix.

To measure the relationship bonds of bank employees, participants' personal perceptions of financial, structural and internal social bonds were evaluated based on Wang's (2014) study. Regarding financial bonds, three types of measurement items were used to determine whether satisfactory economic compensation was provided to employees. For structural bonds, three types of measurement items were used to determine whether financial companies allow employees to determine their working hours and schedules. For internal social bonds, four types of measurements items were used to determine whether employees

Table I.
Demographic
characteristics of
respondents

Variable	Characteristic	Frequency	Percentage
Gender	Men	204	55.9
	Women	161	44.1
Age	20s	83	22.7
	30s	127	34.8
	40s	111	30.4
	50s or older	44	12.1
Academic background	Graduated from high school	90	24.7
	Attending university	12	3.3
	Graduated from university	249	68.2
	Attending or graduated from graduate school	14	3.8
Work experience	Less than 3 years	104	28.5
	More than 3 years and less than 6 years	88	24.1
	More than 6 years and less than 9 years	52	14.2
	More than 9 years and less than 12 years	48	13.2
	More than 12 years	73	20.0
Work position	Employees	185	50.7
	Deputy section chiefs	74	20.3
	Section chiefs	77	21.1
	Head of department or higher rank	29	7.9

received support from their financial company to facilitate good relationships and smooth communication with other members. For external social bonds, three items based on a study by Biong and Ulvnes (2011) were used to determine whether employees received support in developing personal intimacy with customers and sharing information.

To evaluate P-J fit, the extent to which individuals' jobs coincided with their needs was measured using four items from Saks and Ashforth's (2002) study. To evaluate resiliency, the speed of overcoming stressful situations and making recoveries was measured using the four items from the study by Krush *et al.* (2013). To evaluate emotional exhaustion, the degree of emotional exhaustion from one's job was measured using the four items from Wang's (2014) study. To evaluate job satisfaction, the degree of satisfaction toward one's job and company was measured using three items from the study by Jaramillo *et al.* (2009).

To assess the boundary-spanning behavior of bank employees, a total of 13 items were used from the study by Bettencourt *et al.* (2005). To evaluate service delivery behavior, which refers to the manner in which an employee provides the desired level of service delivery to customers, five items were used. To evaluate external representation, the way the corporate image, product and services are promoted to those outside of the company was measured using four items. Finally, to assess internal influence behavior, the degree to which an employee independently initiated communication with co-workers to enhance service delivery, co-workers and the company was estimated using four items.

4. Analysis results

4.1 Measurement model

Prior to conducting hypothesis testing, this study aimed to identify the reliability and validity of the constructs employed. To determine reliability, the internal consistency method was used and both convergent and discriminant validity were determined to confirm validity. To achieve this aim, confirmatory factor analysis was conducted (Hair *et al.*, 1998). For convergent validity, the composite reliability and average variance extracted were examined. The standard of reliability is normally 0.7 and higher and convergent validity can be assumed to be acceptable only when the composite reliability is 0.7 or higher and the average variance extracted is 0.5 or higher (Nunnally, 1978; Fornell and Larcker, 1981). Meanwhile, the discriminant validity can be

evaluated by verifying whether the squared correlations between the constructs are smaller than the average variance extracted or the square root of the average variance extracted is higher than the correlations between the constructs (Fornell and Larcker, 1981).

In total, 41 items were used to measure 11 types of constructs in this study. However, since Item 4 of internal social bonds, Item 4 of resiliency, Items 1 and 2 of service delivery, and Item 3 of internal influence negatively affected both the reliability and the validity, they were deleted.

Based on the confirmatory factor analysis, since the model fits were $\chi^2 = 291.22$ (df = 194, $p = 0.000$); GFI = 0.898; CFI = 0.970; TLI = 0.964; RMR = 0.031; and RMSEA = 0.047, the measurement items can be generally accommodated. Moreover, the indicators that determine reliability and convergent validity were confirmed to exceed the standard level (Table II). After examining the discriminant validity, it was revealed that the correlation between the respective constructs was smaller than the square root of the average variance extracted (Table III).

Construct	Items	Standardized estimate	CR	AVE	Cronbach's α
Financial bonds	FB1	0.941	0.954	0.874	0.956
	FB2	0.970			
	FB3	0.902			
Structural bonds	SB1	0.660	0.840	0.641	0.859
	SB2	0.897			
	SB3	0.906			
Internal social bonds	ISB1	0.848	0.911	0.775	0.851
	ISB2	0.895			
	ISB3	0.705			
External social bonds	ESB1	0.793	0.897	0.744	0.841
	ESB2	0.836			
	ESB3	0.780			
Person–job fit	PJF1	0.768	0.880	0.648	0.859
	PJF2	0.812			
	PJF3	0.774			
	PJF4	0.758			
Resiliency	RES1	0.812	0.893	0.736	0.876
	RES2	0.882			
	RES3	0.825			
Emotional exhaustion	EE1	0.679	0.866	0.618	0.809
	EE2	0.700			
	EE3	0.691			
	EE4	0.811			
Job satisfaction	JS1	0.856	0.908	0.768	0.900
	JS2	0.876			
	JS3	0.868			
Service delivery	SD3	0.781	0.910	0.771	0.835
	SD4	0.861			
	SD5	0.739			
External representation	ER1	0.755	0.902	0.698	0.866
	ER2	0.829			
	ER3	0.833			
	ER4	0.743			
Internal influence	II1	0.837	0.899	0.748	0.853
	II2	0.838			
	II4	0.760			

Table II.
Reliability and
convergent validity
results

Notes: CR, composite reliability; AVE, average variance extracted. $\chi^2 = 907.97$, df = 539, $p = 0.00$, GFI = 0.879, CFI = 0.957, NFI = 0.901, TLI = 0.949, RMSEA = 0.043, RMR = 0.037. All factor loadings are significant ($p < 0.01$)

Table III.
Measurements of
correlations and
discriminant validity

	FB	SB	ISB	ESB	PJF	RES	EE	JS	SD	ER	II
FB	0.935										
SB	0.320**	0.801									
ISB	0.185**	0.288**	0.88								
ESB	0.266**	0.526**	0.560**	0.863							
PJF	0.567**	0.445**	0.418**	0.549**	0.805						
RES	0.335**	0.280**	0.412**	0.384**	0.441**	0.858					
EE	-0.175**	-0.238**	0.018	-0.007	-0.209**	-0.242**	0.786				
JS	0.666**	0.373**	0.374**	0.421**	0.755**	0.548**	-0.291**	0.876			
SD	0.129*	0.217**	0.407**	0.532**	0.326**	0.180**	0.125*	0.290**	0.878		
ER	0.375**	0.440**	0.530**	0.630**	0.598**	0.496**	-0.085	0.662**	0.560**	0.835	
II	0.335**	0.310**	0.487**	0.540**	0.510**	0.462**	0.004	0.582**	0.475**	0.709**	0.865

Notes: FB, financial bonds; SB, structural bonds; ISB, internal social bonds; ESB, external social bonds; PJF, person–job fit; RES, resiliency; EE, emotional exhaustion; JS, job satisfaction; SD, service delivery; ER, external representation; II, internal influence. The number in the diagonal is the square root of the AVE.

* $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$

4.2 Common method bias (CMB)

CMB is a systematic error that occurs when measuring constructs and is the bias that appears when measuring two or more variables using the same method (Billings and Wroten, 1978; Podsakoff *et al.*, 2003). Covariance occurs due to a similar procedure when measuring two or more variables using the same method. When a correlation between the measurement methods exists, it is difficult to be certain of the correlation between the measurement variables, even if validity exists (Podsakoff and Organ, 1986).

This study aimed to identify how bank employees' relationship bonds apply to their psychological responses and behaviors. To this end, the perception, inclination and attitude of bank employees were measured based on the self-reported data collected through the online surveys; the source of their responses was not distinguished; furthermore, the environment or the time of measurement was uniform. Thus, it was necessary to test for CMB. To resolve this matter, this study diagnosed CMB by conducting Harman's single-factor test. Harman's single-factor test can recognize CMB by identifying the number of factors needed to explain variance after analyzing all indicators as an unrotated factor solution in exploratory factor analysis. If variance from CMB exists, only one factor is explored from the factor analysis or most of the variance from the first factor is explained (Podsakoff *et al.*, 2003). This study conducted an unrotated exploratory factor analysis based on the indicator used to measure constructs. A total of nine factors had eigenvalues higher than 1 and the variance of the respective factors was confirmed at 32.66, 10.33, 6.40, 5.54, 4.63, 4.06, 3.51, 3.34 and 2.79 percent. After conducting Harman's single-factor test, the factors were not extracted as one and the factor with the greatest variance did not exceed the majority of the variance.

4.3 Hypotheses testing

After determining the fits of the model suggested in this study, it can be confirmed that the models' levels are acceptable and can be accommodated ($\chi^2 = 1,287.47$ (df = 573), $p = 0.000$); GFI = 0.819; CFI = 0.916; IFI = 0.917; TLI = 0.908; RFI = 0.845; NFI = 0.859; RMR = 0.071; and RMSEA = 0.059). The final result of the model testing is shown in Table IV. The elements comprising the relationship bonds of bank employees – financial bonds ($\beta = 0.48$, $p < 0.01$), structural bonds ($\beta = 0.11$, $p < 0.05$), internal social bonds ($\beta = 0.18$, $p < 0.01$) and external social bonds ($\beta = 0.29$, $p < 0.01$) – had positive effects on P–J fit. Thus, *H1a–H1d* were supported. Next, P–J fit had negative effects on emotional exhaustion ($\beta = -0.11$,

Table IV.
Hypotheses
test results

Path	Standard coefficient	t-Value	Result
Financial bonds → Person–job fit	0.48	9.572**	H1a: supported
Structural bonds → Person–job fit	0.11	1.987*	H1b: supported
Internal social bonds → Person–job fit	0.18	3.160**	H1c: supported
External social bonds → Person–job fit	0.29	4.378**	H1d: supported
Person–job fit → Emotional exhaustion	−0.11	−1.653*	H2: supported
Person–job fit → Job satisfaction	0.80	13.585**	H3: supported
Emotional exhaustion → Job satisfaction	−0.10	−2.451**	H4: supported
Resiliency → Emotional exhaustion	−0.20	−2.980**	H5: supported
Job satisfaction → Service delivery	0.37	6.140**	H8a: supported
Job satisfaction → External representation	0.72	11.733**	H8b: supported
Job satisfaction → Internal influence	0.64	10.721**	H8c: supported
Notes: $\chi^2 = 1,287.47$ (df = 573); $p = 0.00$; GFI = 0.819; CFI = 0.916; NFI = 0.859; TLI = 0.908; RMSEA = 0.059; RMR = 0.071. * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$			

$p < 0.05$) and positive effects on job satisfaction ($\beta = 0.80$, $p < 0.01$). Further, emotional exhaustion had a negative impact on job satisfaction ($\beta = -0.10$, $p < 0.01$). Therefore, *H2–H4* were supported. In addition, resiliency was found to diminish emotional exhaustion ($\beta = -0.20$, $p < 0.01$). *H5* was also supported. Finally, job satisfaction had positive effects on the elements comprising boundary-spanning behavior, that is, service delivery behavior ($\beta = 0.37$, $p < 0.01$), external representation ($\beta = 0.72$, $p < 0.01$) and internal influence behavior ($\beta = 0.64$, $p < 0.01$). Thus, *H8a–H8c* were supported.

4.4 Moderating effects of resiliency

It is necessary to determine whether the resiliency of bank employees has a moderating effect regarding emotional exhaustion. *H6* evaluated whether the effect of reduced emotional exhaustion through P–J fit would be strengthened as the resiliency of bank employees increased. *H7* tested whether the effects of reduced job satisfaction as a function of emotional exhaustion would be weakened as the resiliency of bank employees increased.

To identify the hypothesis related to the moderating effect, this study verified the interaction effect using the bootstrap method and utilizing the process model. The process model can simultaneously process a moderating effect, a mediating effect and a moderated mediation effect, which has a combined and controlled moderating effect, and a mediating effect based on regression analysis in a single analysis framework; statistical significance is verified through the bootstrap method (Hayes, 2013; Preacher and Hayes, 2008). Analysis was conducted using model number 58, which was selected from among the process models suggested by Hayes (2013). Job satisfaction was inserted into Y and P–J fit was inserted into X. Moreover, after inserting emotional exhaustion into M and placing resiliency into W, the analysis was conducted. The moderating effect of resiliency between P–J fit and emotional exhaustion that was suggested in *H6* was determined by investigating the presence of a significant effect from the interaction between P–J fit and resiliency on emotional exhaustion. Based on the analysis, the interaction effect of P–J fit and resiliency on emotional exhaustion was not statistically significant ($\beta = 0.07$, CI = [−0.02, 0.17], $p > 0.05$). Thus, *H6* was not supported. In addition, the moderating effect of resiliency between emotional exhaustion and job satisfaction, which was suggested in *H7*, was determined by examining whether the interaction effect between emotional exhaustion and resiliency had a significant effect on job satisfaction. The analysis showed that the interaction effect between emotional exhaustion and resiliency was not significant for job satisfaction ($\beta = 0.02$, CI = [−0.09, 0.12], $p > 0.05$). Thus, *H7* was also not supported (Table V).

Table V.
Results related to the
moderating effects

Path	Coeff.	Bootstrapping 95% confidence intervals	
		Lower	Upper
<i>(MV = resiliency)</i>			
Person–job fit → Emotional exhaustion	−0.1029*	−0.1996	−0.0063
Resiliency → Emotional exhaustion	−0.1014*	−0.1927	−0.0102
PJF × RES → EE (<i>H6</i>)	0.0726	−0.0245	0.1697
Emotional exhaustion → Job satisfaction	−0.1376*	−0.2321	−0.0431
Person–job fit → Job satisfaction	0.6276**	0.5350	0.7202
Resiliency → Job satisfaction	0.2700**	0.1822	0.3578
EE × RES → JS (<i>H7</i>)	0.0162	−0.0855	0.1179
Notes: 5,000 bootstrapped samples. * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$			

5. Discussion

5.1 General discussion

The financial bonds satisfy the economic needs of bank employees and structural bonds become a job resource for the organization, as they are perceived as the organization's effort to take care of its employees from a policy perspective, which is demonstrated, for example, by flexible working hours (Giannikis and Mihail, 2008; Wang, 2014). Internal social bonds streamline job performance by generating an information exchange process to assist bank employees resolve customer problems (Hu *et al.*, 2016), and external social bonds enable bank employees to accomplish their job goals. Also, social bonds satisfy relationship needs by facilitating interaction between individuals (Liang and Wang, 2005). Thus, the internal and external social bonds of bank employees become job resources and play important functional roles. The analysis showed that relationship bonds improve the P–J fit. Conversely, as the psychological resource related to the satisfaction of the conditions necessary for job performance ability and job performance itself, P–J fit intervened in the job resource factor and job outcome. The psychological response process was then initiated. P–J fit lowered emotional exhaustion and improved job satisfaction; emotional exhaustion was found to inhibit the job satisfaction of employees. In addition, job satisfaction was found to enhance the boundary-spanning behavior of bank employees. Bank employees' job satisfaction improves their behaviors related to external representation, which boosts their service delivery behavior, the corporate image, products and services provided for people outside of the company and internal influence behavior, which leads to communication with colleagues that can enhance service delivery. That is, when employees are satisfied with their job and have a positive attitude, their efforts to make significant accomplishments in their job increase (Netemeyer *et al.*, 1997; Atmojo, 2012; Schmitz and Ganesan, 2014) and lead to their prioritization of the organization and altruistic behavior (Netemeyer *et al.*, 1997; Organ and Lingl, 1995).

Meanwhile, since bank employees' resiliency was found to be a direct factor in lowering emotional exhaustion, it can be considered a personal resource. There were no moderating effects related to the reduction of emotional exhaustion owing to P–J fit or any weakening of negative effects from emotional exhaustion. There can be several reasons for the lack of a moderating effect of resiliency. First, a moderating effect between P–J fit and emotional exhaustion was not found because resiliency entails overcoming and adjusting to highly stressful events (Luthans *et al.*, 2006). Since P–J fit is not the predisposing factor that induces stress and increases emotional exhaustion, resiliency does not moderate it; it also does not moderate emotional exhaustion. Therefore, for resiliency, it is appropriate to identify the moderating effect from the job demand factor on employees' emotional state. Moreover, the inability to reduce the negative effect of emotional exhaustion on job satisfaction is contingent on an individual's personal tendency to make a swift recovery to the point at which resiliency

is not stressed; however, it is anticipated that an individual's attitude toward his or her already-established job due to emotional exhaustion cannot be changed.

5.2 *Managerial implications*

Bank organizations can manage the emotions of employees and induce positive behavior through their relationship bonds. As such, bank organizations must form financial bonds by establishing a compensation system that employees perceive as adequate. Structural bonds constitute another factor, which governs employees' emotional state. Bank organizations can immerse employees in their jobs through a flexible working system (Martin and MacDonnell, 2012) and employees can carry out behaviors related to their job through the balance they strike between work and life. Such an effort by banking organizations not only positively contributes to employee performance by leading to an increase in productivity, but also diminishes the expenses incurred due to their inability to manage their emotional state (Zablah, Franke, Brown and Bartholomew, 2012). Meanwhile, bank organizations must make efforts to strengthen the internal social bonds within their organization. Bank organizations should promote the exchange of information between employees, organize communities within the organization to resolve problems related to sales and customers, and establish a horizontal organizational culture. These efforts will satisfy employees' social sense of belonging. This study also found that external social bonds play a role as a job resource. Bank organizations endeavoring to assist employees in forming good relationships with customers are ultimately able to manage the emotional state of employees. Bank organizations should be unstinting in their support of developing an employee manual to manage customer relationships. Bank organizations should also devise countermeasures against blacklisted consumers who make demanding requests of employees. The employees who respond to the demanding requests and blacklisted consumers become mentally and physically exhausted; in addition, the corporate image may also be negatively affected. Therefore, bank organizations must create a manual for responding to such customers and occasionally discontinue their relationship with them.

Bank organizations can enhance P-J fit by improving the relationship bonds of employees and providing various support systems for regular job education and employee growth. Regarding P-J fit, bank organizations should not merely satisfy the needs of employees or improve their job performance ability through wages, but should also endeavor to satisfy both the abilities-demand and the needs-supplies fit. Bank organizations can also accomplish P-J fit based on their efforts by using diverse recruiting methods to find the members who possess suitable skills or abilities required for adequate job performance.

Finally, among the personal inclinations of bank employees, resiliency lowers emotional exhaustion. Since resiliency is not a fixed individual inclination, bank organizations should endeavor to improve resiliency by developing job training programs that are designed to enhance resiliency. Such efforts will increase the boundary-spanning behavior of employees.

5.3 *Limitations and future research*

First, this study suggested that relationship bonds are the organizational resources related to a job. In addition, it mentioned resiliency as a personal resource of bank employees. Regarding the elements related to bank employees' role, other than those suggested by this study, a variety of other elements could be at play, such as person-organization fit (Yoo *et al.*, 2014). Moreover, the elements related to job requirements were not considered in this study. Since bank employees interact with customers, studies must be conducted after considering the elements of the requirements that reflect such a characteristic. Therefore, future studies should suggest various elements from the job requirements and resources, which reflect the job characteristics of bank employees.

Second, results showed that the resiliency of bank employees did not have a moderating effect. As mentioned previously, owing to the characteristics of resiliency, which are overcoming stressful events and adapting, a moderating effect is expected to appear between the job requirements and emotional exhaustion, which causes stress for bank employees. Thus, it is necessary to identify the moderating effect of resiliency between job requirements and emotional exhaustion by suggesting various job requirements for bank employees.

Third, this study found that the emotional exhaustion of bank employees eventually had a negative influence on boundary-spanning behavior. Although boundary-spanning behavior is expected to have a positive effect on the performance aspect of the bank organization, it is necessary to identify the way it applies to the actual performance of the bank organization. In that sense, future studies must demonstrate how the boundary-spanning behavior influences the actual performance of the bank organization; thus, the importance of discussing the emotional state of bank employees should be emphasized.

Finally, this study targeted bank employees working in Korea; it was conducted to analyze the perception of ordinary bank employees, but its results are difficult to generalize since it only targeted bank employees from a certain specific country. For example, Korea is characterized as being influenced by collectivistic culture and thus a study conducted within this cultural background could have different results than those resulting from countries with an individualistic culture. Therefore, it is necessary to approach the generalization of the results of this study with caution. Further research will be needed to examine any effects that may be attributed to cultural differences by conducting additional studies that target bank employees in the other countries.

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Appendix: Measurement scale items

Financial bonds scales

- My company provides a satisfactory total income.
- My company provides a satisfactory monthly salary.
- My company provides my anticipated wage.

Structural bonds scales

- My company allows me to determine the amount of extra work.
- My company allows me to freely adjust my working hours.
- My company allows me to flexibly manage my work schedules.

Internal social bonds scales

- My company supports me so I communicate well with co-workers.
- My company supports me so I maintain good relationships with co-workers.
- My company supports me so I communicate well with my boss.
- My company supports me so I maintain a good relationship with my boss.

External social bonds scales

- My company supports my customers to ensure they develop close social relationships.
- My company supports my customers so they can become close friends.
- My company supports my customers to allow them to obtain useful information through their relationships.

Person–job fit scales

- To what extent do your knowledge, skills and abilities match the requirements of the job?
- To what extent does the job fulfill your needs?
- To what extent is the job a good match for you?
- To what extent does the job enable you to do the kind of work you want to do?

Emotional exhaustion scales

- I feel burned out from my work.
- I feel fatigued when I get up in the morning and must face another day on the job.
- I feel frustrated with my job.
- I feel tired at work.

Resiliency scales

- I tend to bounce back quickly after hard times.
- It does not take me long to recover from a stressful event.

- It is not hard for me to snap back when something bad happens.
- I usually come through difficult times with little trouble.

Job satisfaction scales

- All in all, how satisfied are you with your present line of work?
- All things considered (i.e. paid promotions, supervisors, co-workers, etc.), how satisfied are you with your present line of work?
- I feel a great sense of personal satisfaction from my line of work.

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Service delivery scales

- I follow customer sale and service guidelines with extreme care.
- I follow up on customer requests and problems in a timely manner.
- Regardless of the circumstances, I am exceptionally courteous and respectful to customers.
- I follow through on promises to customers in a conscientious manner.
- I take the time to understand customer needs (on an individual basis).

External representation scales

- I tell outsiders that this is a great place to work.
- I generate favorable goodwill for my company.
- I say good things about my company to others.
- I encourage others to use my company's products and services.

Internal influence scales

- I make constructive suggestions for sale and service improvement.
- I contribute many ideas for customer promotions and communications.
- I share creative solutions to customer problems with other employees.
- I encourage co-workers to contribute ideas and suggestions for sale and service improvement.

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